

Lexical causatives and their mood choice: The curious case of *recordar*

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Abstract

This squib revisits the claim that causative predicates uniformly trigger subjunctive complements in Catalan (Rigau, 1981; Quer, 1998). While canonical causatives such as *fer* ‘make’ require subjunctive clauses, causative *recordar* ‘remind’ permits the indicative. We argue that mood selection is sensitive not simply to the causative semantics, but to the structural relation between the causative predicate and the embedded proposition. Whereas *fer* directly embeds the propositional content, *recordar* introduces it indirectly through a further embedded predicate that is a part of a periphrastic structure. We suggest that this layered structure fits well into the locality effects of subjunctive selection (Quer, 1998) which, in turn, predict the possibility of indicative in clausal complements of *recordar*.

Keywords: causatives, semi-factives, mood, indicative, subjunctive, Catalan

¹ Note that *va* in (1) and subsequent examples is the present-tense form of the motion verb *anar* ‘go’. When combined with an infinitive, however, it functions as an auxiliary forming the Catalan periphrastic past.

b. *fer* [CpSBJV]

We take *recordar*₁ to preserve the layered configuration (3-a) of the periphrastic structure. Note crucially that the analytic construction of *recordar*₁, *fer recordar*₂, may also take a finite CC of *reocordar*₂, (4). The example in (4) shows that the mood selection of *fer* is local and only affects the immediate CC of *fer*, whereas the CC of *recordés* remains in the indicative (see also Quer, 1998: 47).

- (4) La Maria em va fer [que recordés₂
 the Maria DAT.3SG go.PRS.3SG.IND make.INF that remember.PST.1SG.SBJV
 [que en Pere havia marxat]].
 that the Pere have.IPFV.3SG.IND leave.PTCP
 ‘Maria made me remember that Pere had left.’

Following Karttunen (2012), causative predicates such as *fer* behave as one-way implicatives: in affirmative contexts, they entail their CC, while under negation this entailment disappears. This is confirmed by attempts to contradict the CC: in affirmative contexts, the result is unacceptable (5-a), while in negative contexts, no contradiction arises (5-b), since the entailment no longer holds.

- (5) a. #La Maria va fer que en Pere marxés,
 the Maria go.PRS.3SG.IND make.INF that the Pere leave.IPFV.3SG.SBJV
 i de fet, no va marxar.
 and of fact not go.PRS.3SG.IND leave.INF
 ‘Maria made Pere leave and in fact, he didn’t.’
 b. La Maria no va fer que en Pere
 the Maria not go.PRS.3SG.IND make.INF that the Pere
 marxés, i de fet, no va marxar / però
 leave.IPFV.3SG.SBJV and of fact not go.PRS.3SG.IND leave.INF / but
 va marxar igualment.
 go.PRS.3SG.IND leave.INF anyway
 ‘Maria didn’t make Pere leave but in fact, he didn’t/ but he left anyway.’

However, in constructions with *recordar*₁, negation no longer licenses a causal interpretation of the CC *que en Pere va marxar*, and the truth of the latter is preserved under negation.²

- (6) a. #La Maria no em va recordar que en Pere
 the Maria not DAT.3SG go.PRS.3SG.IND remind.INF that the Pere
 va marxar, i de fet, no va marxar.
 go.PRS.3SG.IND leave.INF and of fact not go.PRS.3SG.IND leave.INF
 ‘Maria did not remind me that Pere left, and in fact, he didn’t leave.’
 b. #La Maria no em va fer recordar que en
 the Maria not DAT.3SG go.PRS.3SG.IND make.INF remember.INF that the

² Given that the content survives under negation, the propositional content of the CC of *recordar*₁ qualifies as a presupposition. This assumption is plausible insofar as *remember* is treated as a (semi-)factive verb.

Pere va marxar i de fet, no va marxar.
 Pere go.PRS.3SG.IND leave.INF and of fact not go.PRS.3SG.IND leave.INF
 ~‘Maria did not remind me that Pere left, and in fact, he didn’t leave.’

Comparing (5) and (6) suggests a consistency with our pretheoretical sketches in (3-a) and (3-b) such that the causative head only targets the intermediate predicate *recordar*₂, and not the CC itself. It shows that the CC ‘that Peter left’ is an immediate CC of *recordar*₂, not *fer*, thus underlying the more complex structure of *recordar*₁. Taken together, these first diagnostics support the assumption that entailment in causative structures is sensitive to the level at which the CC is introduced in the syntactic (de)composition.

Such a structural distinction could also provide a direct explanation for the observed mood asymmetry between *fer* and *recordar*, despite both being causative. If subjunctive selection is sensitive to the immediate embedding of the propositional domain under a causative predicate, then it is expected to arise in configurations where the CP is directly selected by the canonical cases of *fer*. In such cases, the propositional content *p* of the CC is not embedded by any intermediate predicate and is therefore directly selected by the causative verb *fer*, yielding obligatory subjunctive. In contrast, in *recordar*₁ ‘remind’, *p* is not the immediate CC of *fer*, but rather the CC of the lower predicate *recordar*₂ ‘remember’. As a result, *p* is structurally separated from the causative domain by an additional layer of embedding. We suggest that subjunctive selection in causative environments requires a local structural relation between the causative predicate and the CC. This locality effect (Quer, 1998) is a characteristic for subjunctive-selecting predicates, as shown in (7). Note that subjunctive mood in (7-b) is not licensed when the CC is not the immediate CC of the causative verb ([...] indicate CCs of the respective verbs *fer* and *pensar*). Thus, the subjunctive is only licensed in the immediate complement of *fer*.

(7) (Quer, 1998)

- a. Fas [que pensi [que li
 make.PRS.2SG.IND that think.PRS3SG.SBJV that 3SG.DAT
 convé]].
 be-convenient.PRS.3SG.IND
 ‘You make him/her think that it is convenient for her/him.’
- b. *Fas [que pensi [que li
 make.PRS.2SG.IND that think.PRS3SG.SBJV that 3SG.DAT
 convigui]].
 be-convenient.PRS.3SG.SBJV
 ‘You make him/her think that it is convenient for her/him.’

A similar suggestion where locality plays a role was advanced in Quer (1998) for cases of subjunctives under *dir* ‘say’ in Catalan. In such cases, the subjunctive CC functions as the internal argument of a covert causative head. The proposed structure for (8-a) is given in (8-b), where &P denotes a coordination phrase combining two verbal projections (VPs): the lexical verb *dir* ‘say’ and the covert causative head CAUSE, which in turn embeds a CP. In spirit, this formal analysis is therefore similar to our proposal, insofar as the CC in the subjunctive is likewise treated as the argument of a (non-overt) causative head.

- (8) a. Diu que li escriguis.
 say.PRS.3SG.IND that 3SG.DAT write.PRS.3SG.SBJV
 ‘(S)he tells you to write to her/him.’

- b. [_{&P}[VP *diu*] [_{&'}[_& [_{VP} [_{V'} [_V CAUSE] [_{CP} *que li escriguis*]]]]]]]

This is insofar relevant as *recordar* also allows for the subjunctive which would threaten our initial hypothesis. Note, however, that its reading shifts towards a *verbum dicendi* with a manner-interpretation in the sense of ‘say as a reminder’. Take the example in (9) with a subjunctive CC that carries a directive meaning, similar to (8-a) with *dir*.

- (9) El nostre professor ens va recordar que
 the our professor 1PL.DAT go.IPFV.3SG.IND remind.INF that
 estudiéssim més per a la selectivitat.
 study.PST.3SG.SBJV more for to the entrance-exams
 ‘Our professor reminded us to study harder for the entrance exams.’

Given that both readings are directive, it is plausible to apply the analysis for (8-b) to (9). One reason is that the coordination of embedded sentences with different verbal moods is restricted to the sequence IND < SBJV only, as Quer (1998) has argued for *dir*, (10). Compare this with *recordar* (11) in its intended *verbum dicendi*-interpretation which appears to be quite odd, thus further supporting the assumption that *recordar* with a subjunctive receives a reading of ‘say as a reminder’.

- (10) *Diu que li escriguis i que
 say.3SG.PRS that 3SG.DAT write.PRS.3SG.SBJV and that
 t’enyora.
 2SG.ACC-miss.PRS.3SG.IND
 ‘(S)he tells you to write her/him and says that (s)he misses you.’
- (11) ?El nostre professor ens va recordar que
 the our professor 1PL.DAT go.PRS.3SG.IND remind.INF that
 estudiéssim més per a la selectivitat i que aprovar
 study.IPFV.1PL.SBJV more for to the entrance-exams and that pass.INF
 era a les nostres mans.
 be.IPFV.3SG.IND at the our hands
 ‘Our teacher reminded us to study harder for the university entrance exams and that passing depended on us.’

However, this observation remains tentative, calling for further investigation to examine whether the apparent restriction on the coordination of embedded clauses can be attributed to the availability of a *verbum dicendi*-interpretation of *recordar*₁.

3. Conclusion and further implications

We have advanced the idea that *recordar*₁ is a fusion of *recordar*₂ and *fer*, and have assumed that these synthetic forms can be decomposed into their analytical counterparts. This decomposition, in turn, makes the mood selection of *recordar* in its remind-sense transparent. Based on this observation, we submit that the behavior of *recordar* appears to be rather idiosyncratic, since there are few verbs in Catalan that allow, with a single synthetic item, a decomposition of sentences with a double semantic and syntactic possibility: as a non-causative construction (*recordar*₂ ‘remember’), on the one hand, and

as a causative one (*recordar*₁ ‘remind’) on the other. Another verb, although with a different behavior, that also allows these two readings is *interessar*, which can function as a non-causative verb that bears stative semantics (‘to be of interest/interesting’) and as a causative verb (‘to make [someone] become interested’), as proposed in Royo (2019).

Overall, we take the observed sensitivity of mood to the structural distance between the causative head and the propositional domain not as a replacement for semantic accounts of subjunctive, but as evidence that such accounts must be relativized to the syntactic position at which the relevant propositional content is introduced. On this view, causative semantics alone does not determine mood; rather, mood selection is mediated by whether the causative head directly interfaces with the selected CP or whether this relation is rather with an intermediate predicate, as we have argued for the case of *recordar* in its ‘remind’/‘make remember’ sense. Last but not least, we do not claim that the indicative follows directly from causative decomposition alone. Rather, the proposal is that the (semi-)factive properties associated with *recordar*₂ become structurally relevant precisely because the propositional complement is introduced below the causative layer, as seen in the data in (6). Future research will show whether such an analysis can be applied cross-verbally and cross-linguistically to other Romance languages beyond Catalan.

Competing interests

The authors declare no competing interests.

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